

This overlooked corner of Sardinia is made for family holidays



Closer to Africa than Italy, Sardinia's warm waters, reliable weather and knockout coastline have long made it a hit with families. Lesser known are its historical treasures — and there are enough here to rival those of Rome.

The island's south makes the best base for adventures into its historical landscape. Begin at the Nora Archaeological Park, perched on a windswept peninsula, which has a remarkably intact Roman theatre, well-preserved mosaiced bath complex and temple. Kids will love the virtual-reality tour while, from spring, a new museum will display artefacts discovered on site.

Afterwards, swing by the charming town of Pula nearby. It's especially lively come nightfall, when families descend on Piazza del Popolo for pizza, pasta and gelato.



Drive 20 minutes south and you'll reach a prized stretch of Sardinian coastline. Try Su Giudeu, a long sweep of sand with an off-shore island that stronger swimmers will love aiming for. Meanwhile, smaller Tuerredda has the best beach club, with a varied lunch menu and ample seating in the shade. The area is also home to the Forte Village resort, which sits on the sands of Santa Margherita di Pula and offers a wide range of family-friendly accommodation, facilities and restaurants, all surrounded by lushly planted gardens. Kids can enrol in expert-led academies in everything from chess to football, or head to the resort's new nature park, home to Sardinian donkeys and a vegetable garden devoted to sustainable farming. Here, junior visitors can take part in educational workshops and themed evenings under the stars.

Keep your eyes peeled for flamingos during the hour's drive north to Cagliari, the island's underrated capital. Start with a wander around the walled Quartiere Castello neighbourhood, stopping at Frumento for a bargain pizza — just €8.50 (£7.50) for a margherita. At the port, Marina Piccola, E-Boats Sardinia rents out self-drive vessels that are ideal for exploring the surrounding coast — swim secret beaches and sea caves such as Grotta dei Colombi.

The Saint Remy Bastion offers stunning views across Cagliari.

Unesco-listed Su Nuraxi di Barumini is an hour's drive north, in Sardinia's atmospheric interior, its undulating hills covered by maquis shrubland. The structure is one of more than 7,000 nuraghes — beehive-shaped Bronze Age towers — that dot the island, providing the opportunity for family archaeological field trips. Nearby, reserve a table at the agriturismo Is Perdas, which has its own replica nuraghe and an infinity pool, and offers bike rental plus child-friendly cooking classes. The Ollanu family who own the restaurant are passionate advocates of Sardinia's little-known heritage and will proudly show their nuraghe to guests before or after a meal of local dishes such as culurgiones (wheat-shaped stuffed pasta) and seadas (pecorino-filled pastry, drizzled with honey).